

Text One

Yes, Good Grammar Is (Still) Important, and Here's Why

adapted from a blog by Megan Krause

In this passage, the American writer argues that good grammar is important for clear communication.



Why is good grammar important? While texting and verbal slang are widely accepted in many situations, your grammar skills will set you apart in professional settings. Poor grammar skills, fairly or unfairly, can damage you or your brand's credibility and have an impact on the way others perceive you or your brand.

It's not easy being a grammar specialist these days.

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People are sometimes wary of interacting with me. I think they think I keep some sort of file on how well they speak or write. I get that – no one wants to feel constantly judged or afraid to speak out because they might make a mistake. These people might be surprised to learn that I don't have *The Elements of Style*¹ memorized (not all of it, anyway), and I make mistakes, too. Then there's the backlash that comes from those with poor and excellent language skills alike, the notion that my appreciation for good grammar is rooted in authority or a need to feel superior – that at best I'm an uptight slave to the machine and at worst, a judgmental snob worthy of the same contempt I allegedly hold others in.

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Why is grammar important? Well, I'll tell you. But first, you have to understand that when it comes to matters of grammar, there are three groups:

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1. Purists.

These people know and appreciate (sometimes to a fault) the rules of grammar. The purist believes definite rules govern correct usage and failure to follow these rules renders the content in question wrong. These are the ones you go to when you're not sure if it should be 'who' or 'whom'. Purists have a tendency to believe that poor grammar heralds the fall of civilization.

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2. Rebels.

These well-intentioned individuals are more concerned with how people use language than the alleged rules that govern it. They are far too hip and enlightened to be caught up in all your irritating *rules* – grammar belongs to the people, and as such, common usage reigns supreme. 25

3. Don't-know-don't-care.

This one should be self-explanatory, but what the heck: for whatever reason, these people don't know the rules of grammar or can't keep them straight, and they don't understand the big deal, either. You'll find these people rolling their eyes often and adding, 'What's the big deal? You know what I *meant*.' 30

What *is* the big deal? So glad you asked. Let's get to it.

Good grammar is a brand ambassador.

It doesn't matter if you're talking about your personal brand or your business brand – your grammar, spelling and punctuation represent you in the world. They send the reader a message about your authority and attention to detail. They are a trust signal: they say, *I do good work*. However, poor grammar harms your credibility and makes you look careless. In fact, four in ten job applications are rejected due to poor grammar and spelling, according to the global communication skills company Communicaid. People are going to make judgments on your competence and intelligence based on your grammar, whether they realize it or not – and regardless of whether you think it's OK for them to do so. Right or wrong, bad grammar hurts your image. 35 40

It comes down to this: anything great is error-free.

Good grammar helps you communicate clearly and get what you want. 45

Grammar is the groundwork of clear communication. 'The better the grammar, the clearer the message, the more likelihood of understanding the message's intent and meaning,' author William Bradshaw wrote in an article.

And isn't that why you're creating content, regardless of whether it's a CV or a blog post or an essay – aren't you trying to communicate? Good grammar makes content easier to read and understand. If I constantly have to translate your poorly-written sentences into what I think you meant, well I have a lot of room to get your intent wrong, don't I? People don't have time to try to figure out what you mean. If you're not clear, they'll move on to the guy who is. 50

Language is beautiful and powerful and worthy of respect. 55

Humanity, for all its flaws and weaknesses, is a beautiful thing. Who has never been moved to tears by a kind gesture? Who has not gazed in wonder at a starlit night? What's it all about, anyway – this living and dying, these 70-odd years we spend trying to figure out me and you and babies and war and love and heartbreak? Language is the tool with which we try to make sense of it all. It's how we describe and report on ourselves, the world and our reality. We use it to distinguish truth, charm partners, topple governments and make peace with our souls. And as such, it deserves our respect. Good grammar honors the power and beauty of words. 60

¹ *The Elements of Style* – an American English guide to writing style first published in 1920

Text Two

How technology is changing the English Language

adapted from an article by Richard Godwin

In this passage, the writer argues that technology has changed the way we communicate.



There are two ways that you could look at the evolution of the English language in the internet era. You could see a sentence such as 'LOL D@T is teh Rox0rz!!! 111oneleven' (a real example from an online gaming forum) as evidence of the end of civilisation as we know it. Goodness knows there are enough books about 'proper' grammar to suggest as much.

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Canadian linguist, Gretchen McCulloch, takes a different view though. She would like the rule-fiends to relax about young people beginning emails with 'hey' and using too many exclamation marks, and consider a different hypothesis: that if good language is about communicating your intentions clearly, the internet has ushered in a golden age of eloquence. 'There's no moral virtue in using language in the most uptight way,' she insists. 'What we think of as the principles of traditional English usage, a lot of those rules are there to appeal to dead people... Why not write for the people who actually exist?'

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McCulloch wrote a book, *Because Internet*, very much aimed at people who exist. That is to say, it's for people who have struggled to locate the appropriate emoji in a WhatsApp message, or worried about how many exclamation marks to use in an email to their boss, or wondered why old people LIKE SHOUTING in their texts.

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One of the most interesting aspects deals with the ways in which your use of internet language denotes your age and generation. She outlines five types of internet user: *Old internet people* are not what they sound like but rather the tech-savvy founding population of early adopters.

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Full internet people migrated online at a young age and have never questioned it.

Post-internet people are digital natives who have always known the internet.

Semi-internet people, on the other hand, prefer offline relationships.

Pre-internet people, going online for them is like venturing into a foreign land – and they might want their emails printed!

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They all have their habits. Older people tend to be fond of the 'over-literal emoji' – say, using the cat emoji to ask if the cat has been fed. For younger people, emojis are primarily used for intention, says McCulloch. So, it might be 'Good job' with a thumbs-up or 'Good job' with a laughing emoji, which convey different meanings. The people who adopted the internet later in life – the 'semi-internet people' or the 'pre-internet' people – often have a harder time understanding this. 'A lot of young people say to me that they really want their parents to read my book, as the way their parents communicate with them over text sounds aggressive.'

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That opening example, by the way, translates as: 'Laugh out loud, that rocks!' The use of '1' is a parody of the overexcited typing that abounds online, since '!!!!!!!!1111' is what you get if you take your finger off the shift key too soon while typing multiple exclamation marks. Before you try it, note that McCulloch quotes it as an example of the sort of internet speak that was a bit out of date in 2005.

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McCulloch developed her interest in language after picking up a popular linguistics book as a teenager. Her parents were academics and she studied for a Master's in linguistics at McGill University in Montreal. It has clearly been a fun time to be studying language. The internet has rapidly changed the way we communicate, increasing the volume and importance of informal writing. We have had to evolve new ways of expressing irony, tone, gesture, slang, abbreviations, in-jokes, silly accents, etc. They range from signing off with xoxoxoxo to using asterisks to express *emphasis*.

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While in the first decade of the 21st century there was a rash of reports criticising the abbreviation-filled txt spk that teenagers were apparently using. 'We have now turned into people who use some acronyms some of the time – like idk (I don't know) or lol (laugh out loud) – but we don't fill our entire phrases with them,' McCulloch says. Emojis, she adds, are more properly considered as gestures. The most popular emojis represent the body: faces, hands and hearts. Gestures are part of every human language, which helps explain why they have been so easily incorporated.

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'Before the internet most people did not socialise in writing, primarily,' McCulloch says. 'You made telephone calls and you met face-to-face, but writing was almost all done in a formal context. But having this amount of deliberate, informal practice, you need to take account of how the person on the other end is going to interpret your words. That's going to make you a better writer. Good writing is writing that is read the way you intended it to be read.'

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In the past it was mainly novelists and playwrights who worried about how to convey emotion through text. Now, if you're 14, your social life depends on it. McCulloch hopes her book will help clarify this – and reassure those who worry about a supposed decline in linguistic standards. 'There are lots of things to worry about in this world – climate change and so on – but trust me, language change isn't one of them.'

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